

Toshogu Shrine

A beautiful 17th-century Shinto shrine dedicated to the first shogun of Japan's Edo Period



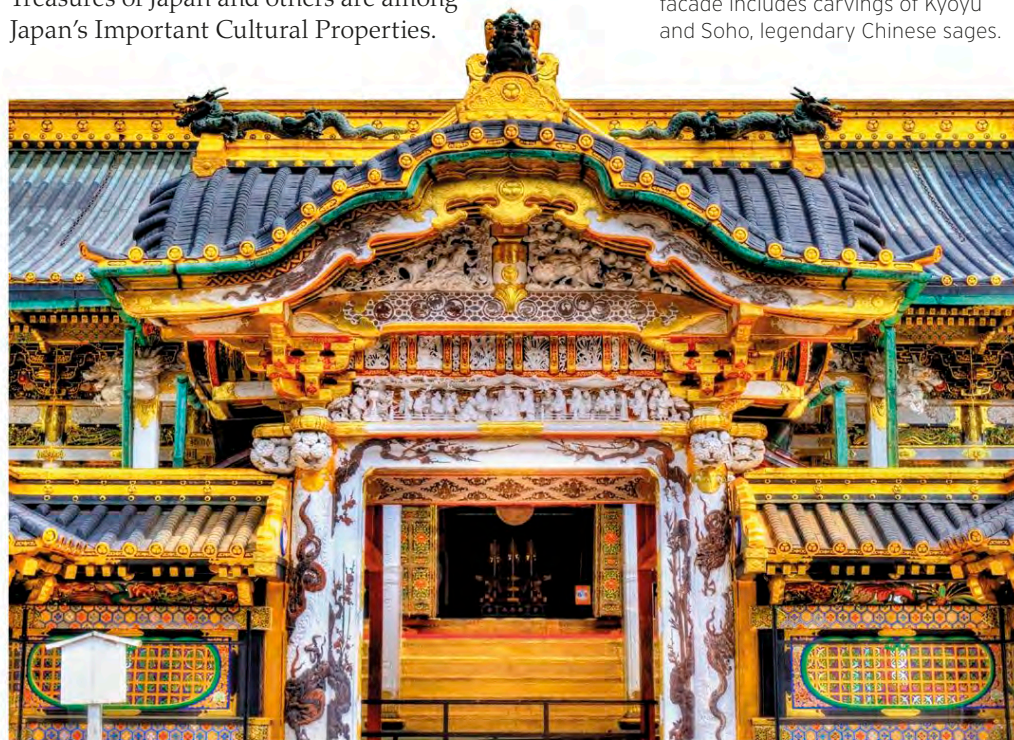
One of over 150,000 Shinto shrines in Japan, the Toshogu Shrine was established in 1617. It was dedicated to Tokugawa Ieyasu, the founder of the Tokugawa shogunate, which ruled Japan from 1600 to 1868—an unprecedented era of peace known as the Edo Period.

The shrine was enlarged to its current size in 1636, when 55 exquisitely carved buildings were completed in just 1 year and 5 months by over 400,000 carpenters. Its expansion cost about \$350 million (¥40 billion) in today's money. A series of paths and stairways wind their way through the forest and the shrine's buildings to the bronze urn containing Ieyasu's remains.

Tradition in design

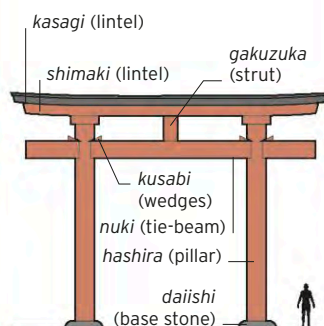
Intricately carved and richly painted and lacquered, the buildings and statues at the shrine provide a kind of visual dictionary of Japanese philosophy and spirituality that features, among other things, the three wise monkeys, lions, peacocks, cranes, and the five elements—earth, water, fire, wind, and ether.

The Toshogu Shrine has been well maintained and regularly renovated from the beginning. Most of the shrine's buildings were included in the Shrines and Temples of Nikko as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1999; five have been designated National Treasures of Japan and others are among Japan's Important Cultural Properties.



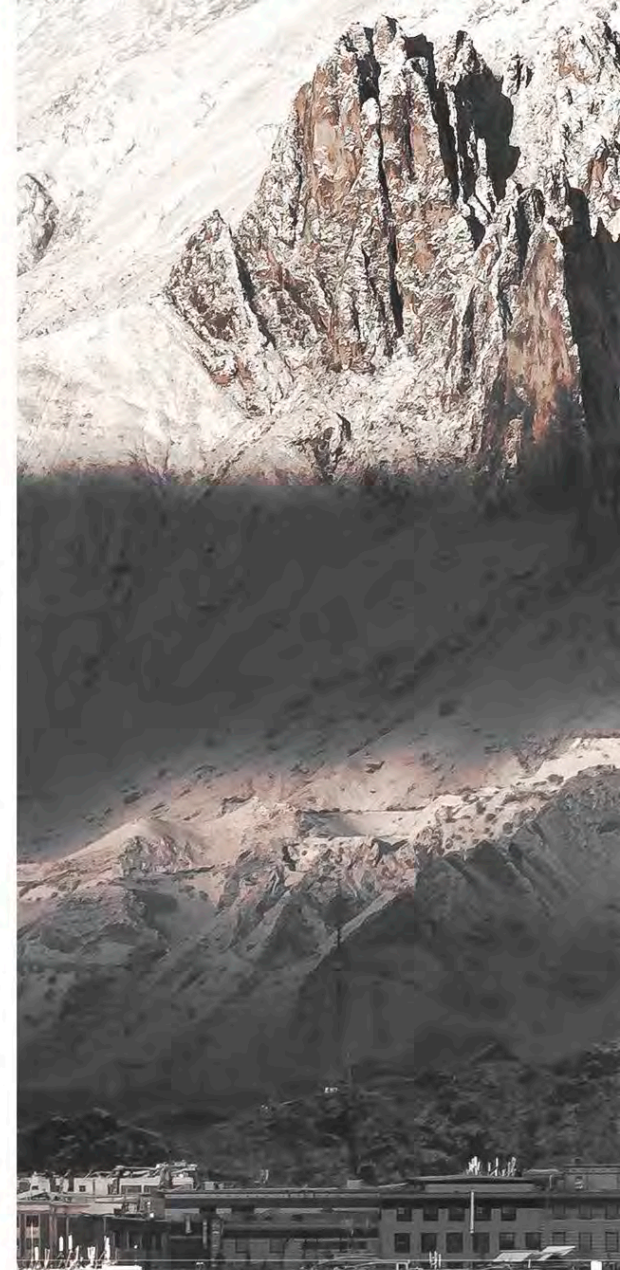
THE ISHIDORII GATE

A *torii* ("bird abode") is a traditional Japanese gate usually found at the entrance to a Shinto shrine. It marks the move from mundane to sacred. The Ishidorii Gate, the first *torii* at the Toshogu shrine, is a stone Myojin-type *torii*, characterized by its curved lintels, as shown in this typical example.



▽ INTRICATE ENTRANCE

The Karamon Gate is one of several elaborate portals at the shrine; its facade includes carvings of Kyoyu and Soho, legendary Chinese sages.



EARTHQUAKE RESISTANCE

The palace's construction helps it withstand earthquakes, which are frequent in the Himalayas. Its outer stone walls taper from an average of 16 ft (5 m) thick at the base to 10 ft (3 m) at the top; this lowers the wall's center of gravity, making it more stable. The walls and internal timber frame create a structure that is both rigid and flexible enough to withstand vibration.

